Speech Marks and Dialogue

Australian Curriculum v9.0 · Year 5 English
(Year 4 review skill)
AC9E4LA12

🎒 Back to School 2027 Warm-Up

Name: _____ Date: _____

LEARNING INTENTION

I can punctuate dialogue correctly, using speech marks, capital letters, commas and end marks.

I CAN…

- ✔ put speech marks around the exact words spoken
- ✔ use capitals, commas and end marks in dialogue
- ✔ start a new line for each new speaker

KEY STRATEGY AND WORKED EXAMPLE

“Where are we going?” asked Tom.

1. Speech marks “ ” wrap only the **spoken words**.
2. The first spoken word has a **capital letter**.
3. The comma, ? or ! goes **inside** the speech marks.
4. Each new speaker starts a **new line**.

Mum said, “Pack your hat.” | “Pack your hat,” said Mum.
When the speaker comes first, use a comma before the speech marks. When the speech comes first, the comma goes inside.

A. TRY TOGETHER – USE THE STRATEGY

1. Add speech marks: Can I borrow your pencil? asked Lily.

_____

_____

2. Add speech marks and a comma: Ben said It’s time for recess.

_____

_____

3. Add speech marks and a comma: The oval is wet said Mr Nguyen.

_____

_____

B. CORE PRACTICE – SHOW YOUR THINKING

4. Rewrite with full punctuation: we are going to the beach said dad

_____

_____

5. Rewrite with full punctuation: what time does the bus leave asked priya

_____

_____

B. CORE PRACTICE (CONTINUED)

6. Rewrite with full punctuation: **mum said pack your hat and drink bottle**

7. Rewrite with full punctuation: **watch out yelled sam**

8. Rewrite with full punctuation: **ms taylor said please line up quietly**

9. **Spot the mistake.** Rewrite correctly: **“Where is my hat.” asked Zoe.**

10. **Spot the mistake.** Rewrite correctly: **Tom said “I’m ready”.**

11. **Spot the mistake.** Rewrite correctly: **“I love footy” said Ava.**

12. Turn into dialogue: **Tom told Mia that he was hungry.**

C. CHALLENGE – APPLY IT IN YOUR WRITING

13. **Split speech.** The speaker interrupts the sentence. Punctuate it: **the canteen sells sausage rolls said jack and i love them**

14. Write a **4-line conversation** between two students at the school gate on the first day of Term 1. Start a new line for each speaker and punctuate every line.

Watch Out! The end mark (. ? !) and the comma always sit **inside** the closing speech marks. Only the words that are actually spoken go inside.

💡 **Parent Tip:** Read a favourite story together. Ask your child to point to where the spoken words begin and end, then find a line where the speaker comes first and one where the speech comes first. Notice where the commas sit.

🎯 My Term 1 Goal: This term I want to get better at _____

Answer and Teacher Page

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Name: _____ Date: _____

ANSWERS

1. “Can I borrow your pencil?” asked Lily.

2. Ben said, “It’s time for recess.”

3. “The oval is wet,” said Mr Nguyen.

4. “We are going to the beach,” said Dad.

5. “What time does the bus leave?” asked Priya.

6. Mum said, “Pack your hat and drink bottle.”

7. “Watch out!” yelled Sam.

8. Ms Taylor said, “Please line up quietly.”

9. “Where is my hat?” asked Zoe. (question mark inside, not a full stop)

10. Tom said, “I’m ready.” (comma before the speech marks, full stop inside)

11. “I love footy,” said Ava. (comma inside)

12. Sample: Tom said, “I’m hungry.” Accept any correctly punctuated version, such as Tom said to Mia, “I am hungry.”

13. “The canteen sells sausage rolls,” said Jack, “and I love them.”

14. Open response. See checklist below.

TEACHER NOTES

Marking checklist for Q14: a new line for each speaker • speech marks around spoken words only • capital letter at the start of each speech • comma, ? or ! inside the closing speech marks • the conversation makes sense for a first day at school.

Common errors: putting the full stop outside the speech marks, putting a full stop instead of a comma when the speaker follows, speech marks around words that are not spoken, and forgetting the capital letter in the second part of split speech (it stays lower case in Q13: “and I love them”).

Support: highlight the spoken words in one colour before adding speech marks.

Australian Curriculum v9.0: AC9E4LA12 (Year 4 review): understand that punctuation signals dialogue through quotation marks and that dialogue follows conventions for the use of capital letters, commas and boundary punctuation.